

urge to harm people: Miranda works with Fidelity, a leading investment firm in Delhi. He says that he has never felt an urge to replicate his activities in *Doom* or *Quake* in real life.

However, the way these people interpret delusion is significant. Says Varun, "Actually, my gaming life and my real life are separate. I have never actually felt the need to shoot down hordes of demons escaping from the gates of hell, really." Rohira strongly objects to suggestions of

delusion: "Definitely not. Or everyone playing *Counter-Strike* would have a desert eagle." All these interpretations of reality, tellingly, are still in terms of the game!

None of them had an opinion about why extreme, gruesome incidents could happen—such as the one in which teenagers in the US last year shot cars à la *Grand Theft Auto III*, or the Los Angeles multiplayer tournament incident wherein a player held a gun to an opponent's head.

The doctors though, have an explanation. They attribute such recklessness and irritability to a marked lack of exercise. Gamers have hyperactive, hyper-alert brains and relatively less physical exercise, which is why they become fidgety and restless.

Game developers, though, disagree. Samrat Sharma, on behalf of VBeing Software, programmers of Kawabonka.com, an online game site, argues that it is just as possible to become a deranged killer by playing *GTA III* as it is to become a pro golfer by playing *Tiger Woods PGA Tour*. If only talented people can become pro golfers outside of the game, only true psychopaths can kill people outside of the game.



Reggie, ace gamer, management trainee, dotting friend

It is as possible to become a deranged killer by playing *GTA III* as it is to become a pro golfer playing *Tiger Woods PGA*

Samrat Sharma
Game Developer

The Pain

It is not fair to comment on the general knowledge of people based on a few questions (see box "Reality Check"), but except for the last question, most of the other stuff is somehow available on the Internet or is related to gaming. The people quizzed should have been able to answer most of the questions. This was an indication that most gamers we studied show a marked lack of interest in the outside world.

Dr Rao attributes this to preoccupation: when a person has left something half-done, he or she is occupied with it for the time when he or she is not doing it.

In psychiatric parlance, this is the Zeigarnik effect. It is similar to when you are reading an interesting novel at night, and cannot sleep until you finish it. This preoccupation makes it difficult for gamers to focus on other tasks.

Thus, social as well as physical activities suffer. Problems with bone and muscle growth crop up. Sitting constantly in front of a computer results in a slouch. Eye strain and neck strain is on the rise. Growth is stunted.

Dr Choksi feels addiction is more often than not a problem associated with some psychiatric condition that needs to be treated. It appears that people who are shy, introverted, prone to depression, or possessing a schizoid personality are vulnerable to any form of addiction, games included.

A well-balanced individual entertains himself with a game for a while, and then gives it up. People with problems cling to the game.

The Idea

Developers in India recognise the potential of games and are gearing up for the next wave of gaming. Sharma of VBeing sheds light on what goes on behind a successful game. For an immersive experience, the most important aspect is suspension of disbelief.

The moment the player surrenders his senses

Wasting The Pie

Ever wondered why the guy/gal next door has a bevy of friends and you don't? (S)he doesn't play games! Time to find out. Get a pen and paper and write down the following:

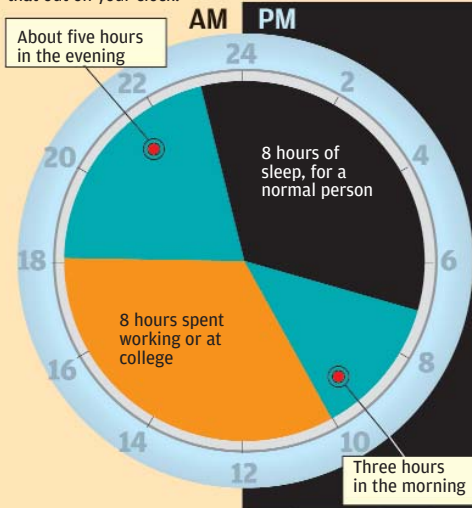


Who are you? Son/daughter, brother/sister, friend/colleague? Let that be your role in life. Write it down.



Identify your goals: What do you want to be? Sportsman? Doctor? Writer? Manager? Want to have a great physique? A popular face in college with lots of friends? Want to learn the guitar and impress? Write this down too.

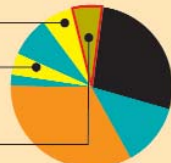
Draw a clock like the one on the right. It is ticking. It is the average day. You spend eight hours at work/or college. Point that out on your clock.



Point out how much time you can spare for your roles and goals. Are all the people you need to share your life with to achieve your goals as well as roles able to give you time in those two little windows?

Mark the time when you play games. Note the overlapping times. That is when you are losing out on your goals

Note the overlapping time



Remember, cutting down on sleep means your body clock cycle suffers. The next day starts late, and there is a further skew in the time others are able to give you. Your work/studies might suffer too.

Courtesy: Aavishkaar